



NITISH WITH MODI (LEFT); PASWAN AND LALU (BELOW)



THE JD(U)-BJP ALLIANCE HAS THE UPPER HAND AS THE CONGRESS IS DIVIDED AND THE LALU-PASWAN DUO'S OPTIONS ARE LIMITED.

and Paswan, who turned their parties into family fiefdoms.

So far, his twin targets of development with aggressive social justice have precipitated electorally. With an eye on the vote bank, he has hiked the dearness allowance of state government employees and increased salaries of the Special Auxiliary Police personnel. Recently, the state cabinet also approved Rs 797 crore for the chief minister's pet schemes of giving uniforms and bicycles to school children. In February this year, his deputy Modi presented a revenue

surplus budget of Rs 53,927 crore.

The expedience of politics seems to have made Nitish allow minor deviations between what he preaches and what he practices. Since taking over as the chief minister on November 24, 2005, Nitish has only expanded his Mandal club by adding Mahadalits (disadvantaged Dalits) and some minority support thanks to his pronounced pro-Muslim policies. Today, both Paswan and Lalu know that Nitish has been deftly trying to eat into their vote-bank. Notwith-

standing his insistence on casteless politics and promotion of sub-nationalism, he has not missed rallies and meetings convened by various caste groups. Be it one held by the Brahmin Samaj Rajnitik Chetna Samiti or a Mahadalit meeting, he has attended them all—with an eye on the polls.

His detractors allege that Nitish has been playing the caste card with deft perfection. His Mahadalit experiment has seen inclusion of 21 of the 22 Dalit castes in Bihar in the Mahadalit list for special benefits. Though the 22nd caste, the Dusadhs—identified with rival LJP chief Ram Vilas Paswan—has not been included in the list, separate promises have been made to them too. This leaves one to wonder why the categorisation was needed at all.

Nitish has also been mixing Mandal with progressiveness. His decisions to reserve 20 per cent panchayat seats for EBCs and 50 per cent for women is a case in point. These were shrewd political moves, which helped him expand his Mandal mat for a huge chunk among the backward castes, besides creating a new political constituency of women in his support. His decision to back the Women's Reservation Bill even when his party president Sharad Yadav opposed it is a deliberate attempt to break out of the brand of Mandal politicians whose significance is being questioned.

While Nitish has been quick in taking stands when it mattered, he has also been good at prevaricating when realpolitik required it. His putting on hold the *bataidari* (land to the tiller) programme is a case in point. He has done it after a section of upper caste leaders ganged up against him. Nitish's focus is clearly on consolidating his positives, besides, of course, trying to make his adversaries slip down the ladder.

Since both fronts would take enormous energy and political capi-